persisted, there was a greater distribution of power in the world, with the rise of a number of global and "regional influentials."[82] Brzezinski emphasized the need to look beyond Atlanticism and trilateralism, and expand relations with the regional influentials—and India was in this category, which also included Brazil, Indonesia, Iran, Nigeria, Saudi Arabia, and Venezuela.[83]

Thus a few days after Carter's inauguration, when Brzezinski instructed National Security Council (NSC) staff to draft letters from the president to "key foreign leaders," Gandhi's name was on the list (Brezhnev and West German chancellor Helmut Schmidt were the only other two identified by name).[84] Carter also sent his mother to India for a goodwill visit. Brzezinski noted the warm welcome and the good press she (and the US) received, but he simultaneously wanted to manage expectations in India.[85]

Carter wrote to Gandhi offering a new start. Addressing prevailing Indian complaints, he said his administration recognized India's "key role in Asia" and its important role on global issues. He emphasized that the US had "no interest in weakening India's regional or global position" or interfering in its domestic politics.[86]

Indian commentators expected an inevitable improvement after the Nixon and Kissinger era. Moreover, except on nuclear issues, Carter had spoken positively about India.[87] Gandhi welcomed the "new beginnings" that the president offered. But Brzezinski saw "clouds on the horizon" with India: a potential cutoff in US nuclear fuel supply to the Tarapur reactor, reduction of economic assistance, and allegations about a spy ring.[88] More immediately, there was uncertainty about who would emerge victorious in the Indian election.

Administration analysts expected the mid-March elections to be "very close," with an unstable government emerging regardless of which party led it.[89] Gandhi told visiting senator Charles Percy (R-IL) that she was pessimistic about her political prospects.[90] Lead South Asia staffer on the NSC, Thomas Thornton, however, expected her to pull off a majority. If she lost, he observed, "we are in for a substantially different ballgame."[91]

And she did lose, bringing to power the Janata Party (JP). American analysts expected this party to develop "relations with the US, USSR, and PRC within a framework of non-alignment." The JP's electoral plank had called for "genuine non-alignment free from attachment to any super